know a show will have credibility only if it has trusted voices from industry experts, journalists, academics, lawyers, police officials, sociologists, criminal psychologists, among others. "About time people with specialised skill sets come," says Abhishek, who wants to set up an inhouse research wing at Discovery.

As long-form documentary storytelling catches the audience's fancy, OTT platforms are keen to sign up directors and technicians who work in features. In fact, traditional documentary filmmakers rarely spearhead unscripted content on streaming due to the timelines attached. "Their mindset is different. If you are shooting a documentary, you don't know when it will get over," says Kanwar. "[For them], it's purely about the art form rather than the strategy of a company expecting content to be churned out on an annual basis." For filmmaker Tanuja Chandra, whose credits include the film *Qarib Qarib Singlle* and the documentary feature *Aunty Sudha Aunty Radha* (available on bookmyshow stream), directing *wedding.con* was a no-brainer. "I was shocked to learn about the scale at which women were being duped," she says. "It was a means to explore the culture we're in the midst of, which values and treasures marriage so much."

Chandra had to find a new visual language to shoot reconstruction (restaging events with actors in the absence of real footage) sequences for the series. "I had my own question—is it any less than a pure doc because of it?" she says. But she found scope for innovation within it. "We can break more boundaries," she says, "maybe bring in animation?" She also hopes that OTT inculcates a habit of documentary-watching in audiences and pushes them to explore more. "It is one of the great formats and highly revered around the world with some beautiful, artistic, sublime work done in it," says Chandra, citing some of her favourites, including *The Puppet Master* [Netflix] and Oscar-nominated *All that Breathes* [JioCinema]. "I hope documentaries keep growing in stature [in India]."

Producer Guneet Monga's banner Sikhya Entertainment is doing a commendable job of doing so with *Period. End of Sentence.* and *The Elephant Whisperers*, both of which won the best documentary short Oscar. For her, it is about finding "distinct local stories" that appeal to "global audiences". "Documentaries cannot be planned and manufactured. They come from within.... They are shot vérité style; it is real life and requires a lot of patience," Monga told INDIA TODAY last year after *The Elephant Whisperers* was nominated. "It will be nice to have more funding opportunities, a stable funding structure, more showcasing, more platforms celebrating documentary filmmakers." Monga's next collaboration with Netflix is a documentary on controversial rapper Yo Yo Honey Singh.



FILMING YO YO
Monga's next is a Netflix documentary on the rapper



"DOCUMENTARIES CANNOT BE PLANNED AND MANUFACTURED. THEY COME FROM WITHIN. THEY ARE SHOT VÉRITÉ STYLE. IT IS REAL LIFE AND TAKES IMMENSE PATIENCE"

–GUNEET MONGA
Founder, Sikhya Entertainment

THE ROAD AHEAD

The Indian non-fiction landscape is teeming with stories that can whet viewer appetite as well as any fiction show can. If only getting things done was a tad easier. Sport remains an unexplored genre. Getting celebrities on board to experiment with the format remains a hard sell, with many seeing it as a swan song of their careers. It doesn't help that they "are reluctant to open up" even after signing on the dotted line, says one creator. Thoroughly researched, strong pitches are rare, laments Abhishek. Barring the three international streaming platforms and a few like DocuBay, MUBI and bookmystream, the avenues for non-fiction programming are limited.

Despite the odds, the unscripted ecosystem is still managing to corner a sliver of the content pie. Netflix recently announced the February 23 release of *The Indrani Mukerjea Story - Buried Truth*, India Today Originals' four-part series on the shocking Sheena Bora murder case; Amazon Prime will air *The Angry Young Man* on the iconic screenwriting duo Salim-Javed, and Discovery Plus recently unveiled the third instalment of its popular Secrets franchise with *Secrets of the Buddha Relics*. Reality, it seems, is here to stay. ■